

INDIAN SOCIETY — PART 2

Anthropology Optional Foundation | Paper 2 (Ch. 3.1 & 3.2) | Sarthi IAS — Nataraj Sir

UPSC CSE 2026 — EXAM-READY NOTES

INDIAN SOCIETY — HANDOUT 2

RACIAL CLASSIFICATION

Risley, Guha, Sarkar

PURUSHARTHA

Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha

VARNASHRAMA

4 Varnas × 4 Ashramas

FINA & REBIRTH

4 Debts + Samsara cycle

KARMA

Action, Fate vs Agency

CASTE SYSTEM

Ghurye, Dumont, Varna vs Jati

1. CLASSIFICATION OF INDIAN POPULATION — Risley, Guha, Sarkar

Scholar	Method	Key Types	Strengths	Weaknesses
Risley (1915)	Anthropometry (body measurements — head, nose)	7 types under 3 groups: Dravidian, Indo-Aryan, Mongolian	First systematic attempt in India; described Rajputs, Pathans, Marathas; showed link between race, caste, region	Scytho-Dravidian/Mongolo-Dravidian labels criticised; didn't recognise tribals separately; Haddon : oldest stratum = pre-Dravidian jungle tribes
B.S. Guha (1931)	Anthropometric data from 1931 Census	6 divisions: Negrito, Proto-Australoid, Mongoloid, Mediterranean, Western Brachycephals, Nordic	More data-based; widely used baseline; linked racial types with census data	Sarkar (1959) found no Negrito traits among Kaders; overstated brachycephalisation ; method (coefficient of racial likelihood) not universally accepted; called India "paradise of diversification" — exaggerated
S.S. Sarkar (1954)	Cephalic index (head breadth-to-length ratio)	6 elements: Australoid, Indo-Aryan, Irano-Scythian, Mundari, Far Eastern, Mongolian	More precise head measurements; India mainly dolichocephalic (long-headed); corrected Guha — denied Negrito; added Irano-Scythian & Far Eastern	Still stuck in racial typology while anthropology moving to population genetics ; narrow focus on cephalic index; not widely adopted outside India

2. PURUSHARTHA — The Fourfold Path of Life (Paper 2, Ch. 3.1)

PURUSHARTHA = "Object of Human Pursuit"

DHARMA

Duty, righteousness, moral law — CENTRAL

ARTHA

Wealth & power through righteous means

KAMA

All desires, impulses — balance body & mind

MOKSHA

Liberation from cycle of life & death

A. DHARMA — The Central Pillar

P.V. Kane — Four Dimensions of Dharma:

1. Rights & duties as a human | 2. Duties as an Aryan community member | 3. Special duties as a society member | 4. Obligations in changing stations of life

Dharma vs Religion — Key Contrast

Aspect	Dharma (Wider Idea)	Religion (Narrower Idea)
Nature	Duty, righteousness, moral law — sustains individual & society	System of faith, belief, worship, rituals tied to a community
Scope	Eternal, universal (<i>Sanatana Dharma</i>), action-oriented: "What is right to do here and now?"	Can vary by time/place; often emphasizes external practice
Focus	Inner compass — combines law, ethics, duty, cosmic order	May harden into ritualism, dogma, or external identity

Radhakrishnan:

"Dharma is not mere belief, but a principle of right living that directs human destiny."

Wilhelm Halbfass:

Dharma cannot be translated as "religion" — it is wider, combining law, ethics, duty, and cosmic order.

Dharma Across Traditions

Tradition	Dharma Teaching	Key Points
Hinduism	Dharma guides Artha & Kama, paves way for Moksha	Yudhishtira-dog story: refused to abandon dog (symbol of dharma) even for heaven — dharma > religious reward
Buddhism	Dhamma — universal law of righteousness	Ethical conduct & compassion > ritual; Four Noble Truths + Eightfold Path are dharmic, not dogmatic. Max Weber: made ethics center of practice
Jainism	Dharma = Ahimsa (non-violence)	<i>Das-dharma</i> (10 virtues): forgiveness, humility, truth, renunciation; practice ahimsa = follow true dharma

Case Study: Yudhishtira and the Dog (Mahabharata)

When offered heaven, Yudhishtira refuses to abandon the dog (symbol of dharma/loyalty). Shows: **dharma must be upheld even above religious reward.**
"Heaven can be lost, but dharma cannot be abandoned."

B. ARTHA, KAMA & MOKSHA

Purushartha	Meaning	Key Points	Scholar / Link
ARTHA	Non-greedy acquisition of wealth & power through righteous manner	Wealth is means to an end, not an end itself; necessary only to fulfill dharmic social obligations	Kautilya (Arthashastra) : wealth only when it serves larger social good → echoes in ESG, CSR
KAMA	All desires in man — impulses, instincts (not just bodily)	Corrective balance between body & mind needed; not mere sensuality	Links to mental health rights, gender equality, LGBTQ+ rights, responsible digital use
MOKSHA	Liberation from endless cycle of life & death (samsara)	Also called <i>mukti</i> ; from Sanskrit <i>muc</i> ("to free"); absorption of self into eternal bliss	N.A. Nikam : proper analogy = "a river joining the ocean" (from Upanishads)

Paths to Moksha — Trimarga (Bhagavad Gita)

Yoga	Path	Description
Karma Yoga	Path of Action	Selfless action without attachment to fruits
Bhakti Yoga	Path of Devotion	Devotion to Ishvar (God)
Jnana Yoga	Path of Knowledge	Self-realization through wisdom
Raja Yoga	Path of Meditation	Making "Four Yogas" / "Four paths to realization"

Ethical & Philosophical Basis + Contemporary Relevance

Principle	Classical Basis	Contemporary Relevance
Integration of material & spiritual	Balances Kama, Artha, Dharma, Moksha; prevents one-sided development (Radhakrishnan)	Work-life balance; holistic well-being; value education
Primacy of Dharma	Without Dharma, Artha → greed, Kama → indulgence	Ethical governance; anti-corruption; SC judgments on equality; climate activism (Greta Thunberg)
Teleological vision	Life has direction & purpose; Moksha = final release	Debates: Is pursuing justice, equality, rights a more immediate form of liberation?
Quest for inner freedom	Moksha = transcendence	Mindfulness, yoga, spiritual tourism; burnout, consumerism → search for meaning beyond material success
Public service frame	Purushartha = moral compass for civil servants	Dharma (justice) Artha (resource mgmt) Kama (human welfare) Moksha (personal integrity)
Global parallels	Deva Rina (debt to nature)	SDGs echo Purushartha: ethics, prosperity, well-being, long-term balance; climate justice

3. VARNASHRAMA DHARMA — Ashram System

VARNASHRAMA DHARMA

VARNA

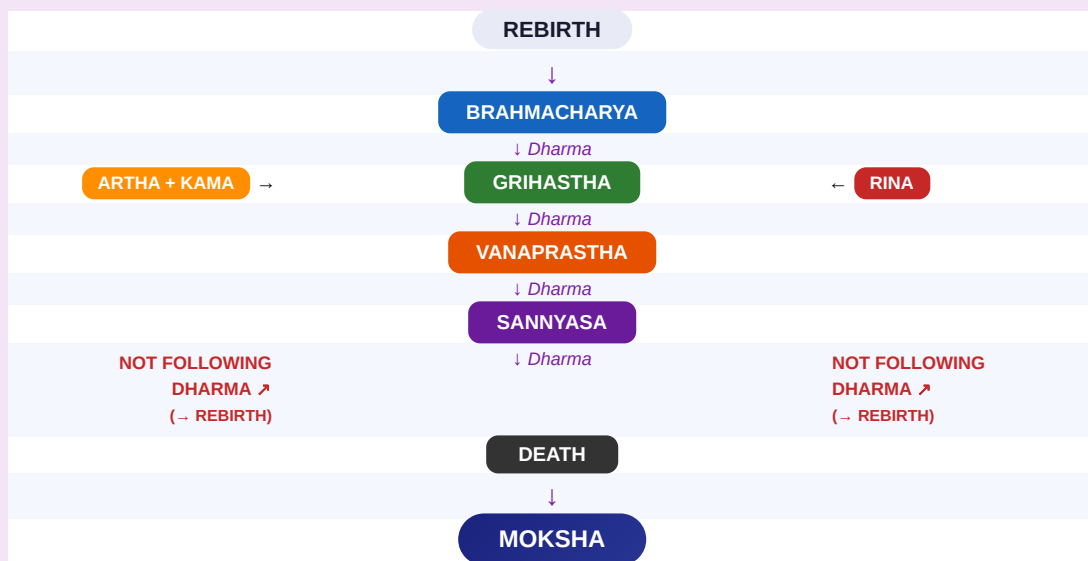
WHAT to do
Brahmin | Kshatriya | Vaishya | Shudra

ASHRAMA

WHEN to do it
Student | Householder | Retiree | Renunciate

Together: "What is one's duty, according to one's role in society and one's stage of life" — both a **social code** and a **spiritual framework**

ASHRAM LIFECYCLE FLOW (from class diagram)



Class note: "Shouldn't it be like this??" — student questioned whether the REBIRTH branch should connect back differently when dharma is NOT followed at ANY stage (not just at the end). The diagram shows two "Not Following Dharma" paths on left & right sides, both looping back to REBIRTH at the top.

The Four Ashramas — Detailed Breakdown

Ashrama	Focus	By Varna	Key Example
1. Brahmacharya (Student)	Dharma — attain knowledge; piety, self-denial, discipline; non-indulgence in Artha/Kama	Brahmin: Vedas, sciences under guru Kshatriya: warfare, archery Vaishya: agriculture, trade Shudra: crafts, service skills	Nachiketa — refused wealth & pleasures, insisted on knowledge of truth
2. Grihastha (Householder) MOST CRUCIAL	Artha + Kama under Dharma; initiated through vivah (marriage); reproduction, wealth, education, helping society	Brahmin: teach, rituals Kshatriya: protect, rule justly Vaishya: honest trade Shudra: service, cultural arts	Sustains ALL other Ashramas through wealth, taxes, hospitality, reproduction
3. Vanaprastha (Retirement)	Transition from Artha/Kama → Moksha ; retire into forest, meditation with minimal needs; hands over responsibilities	Brahmin: withdraw, meditate, write Kshatriya: hand over kingdom Vaishya: live simply, charity Shudra: pass on skills	Dhritarashtra & Gandhari — after the war, retired to forest for meditation
4. Sannyasa (Renunciation)	Total detachment ; links with family completely cut off; complete renunciation of material desires; focused on Moksha	Brahmin: wander as ascetic Kshatriya: lay down arms, embrace peace Vaishya: leave wealth Shudra: devote to prayer	Yudhishtira — renounced throne, journeyed to Himalayas; attained liberation by refusing to abandon dharma (dog)

Interrelation of Ashramas & Purusharthas + Contemporary Relevance

Ashrama	Purushartha Focus	Contemporary Link
Brahmacharya	Dharma: learning, discipline, respect	NEP 2020 — ethics & citizenship education; character-building in youth
Grihastha	Artha & Kama under Dharma	Work-life balance, consumerism debates, responsible parenting
Vanaprastha	Gradual detachment → Moksha	Retirement planning, volunteering, community service
Sannyasa	Moksha — worldly pursuits given up	Minimalism, spiritual retreats, eco-conscious lifestyles

Varnashrama Dharma: What It Ensured

- **Social harmony** — assigning duties according to Varna
- **Personal discipline** — dividing life into stages of responsibility & detachment
- **Spiritual purpose** — keeping Moksha as the final aim

"Varna tells you what to do, Ashrama tells you when to do it. Together, Varnasrama Dharma ensured that life was socially ordered, ethically grounded, and spiritually directed toward liberation."

4. RINA (DEBT) & REBIRTH

RINA — The 4 Sacred Debts

DEVA RINA

Debt to God — prayer, yagnas, conservation

RISHI RINA

Debt to Guru — learn & propagate wisdom

PITRA RINA

Debt to Parents — continue lineage, customs

ATITHI RINA

Debt to Guests — remembrance & service

Core Concept of Rina

- Debts = **expression of gratitude** for gifts received from the world — **not meant to be a burden**
- Taking from the world without giving back → **additional karmic bondage**
- Every Hindu is **born with debt** — obliged to repay to achieve salvation; failure → endless cycle of birth & death

Bhagavad Gita:

"Evil is his being, sensuous is his delight, in vain, O Partha, that man lives." (on those who consume without giving back)

Types of Rina — Detailed

Type	Debt To	How Repaid	Modern Parallel
Deva Rina	God / Nature	Prayer, sacrifices, yagnas, conservation — leaving world better than received	Planting trees, environmental conservation, honouring nature
Rishi Rina	Guru / Sages	Learning, propagating wisdom, adding to knowledge; guru dakshina	Volunteering in education, knowledge sharing
Pitra Rina	Parents / Ancestors	Continuing lineage through procreation; customs, traditions like pind daan	Organ donation (giving life), intergenerational care
Atithi Rina	Guests	Showing remembrance and serving them	Supporting refugees; COVID community kitchens

The Rina Cycle

BORN IN DEBT → Spends entire life repaying = **DHARMA**



Done dutifully without expectations → Liberated from all debts = **MOKSHA**

Done half-heartedly/conditionally → Entrapped in web of **KARMA** → **REBORN** with burden of debt

Western vs Indian Model of Debt

WESTERN MODEL

- Not born in debt** — owe nothing until successful/rich
- Based on Abrahamic concepts: **zakat** (Islam), **tithe** (Christianity)
- Freedom from obligation is the default

INDIC MODEL

- Born with debt** to family, culture, nature by virtue of being alive
- Based on **Rinna** — lifelong obligations
- No escape** from karmic cycle until all debts repaid

Deeper Link: Varnashrama × Rina

#	Link	Key Point
1	Duties = moral debts	Varnashrama tells WHAT & WHEN; Rina explains WHY. Kane : Dharma = not just rules of conduct but recognition of obligations
2	Grihastha = hub of repayment	Feeding guests (Atithi), caring for parents (Pitra), supporting teachers (Rishi), offerings to gods (Deva) — all in householder stage
3	Liberation through responsibility	Fulfilling Rina sincerely = stepping stone to Moksha; neglect → rebirth. Parallels climate justice — climate debt of developed nations
4	Gratitude & interdependence	Arvind Sharma : Hindu thought placed duties at heart of ethics (vs Western rights-focus). India's Supreme Court frames rights within duties
5	Critiques	Ambedkar : Varna tied duties to birth → justified hereditary hierarchies. Feminists : If debts central, why is women's unpaid labor not recognized?
6	Modern civic life	COVID-19: frontline workers = Rishi Rina; community kitchens = Atithi Rina
7	Time-bound vs Timeless	Ashrama = temporal (stages); Rina = eternal (debts lifelong, even for renunciates)

Rebirth — Concept & Debates

- Soul returns in new body/form, influenced by **karma** of past life
- Doctrine: every human has an **everlasting and imperishable soul** — persists even when body destroyed
- **Origin**: First mentioned in **Satapatha Brahmana** ; linkage with karma = post-Vedic development
- **Samkhya tradition**: If disciple stays → **super conscious ecstasy**; if leaves → **nirvikalpa samadhi**

Debates on Rebirth

Perspective	View
Classical Hindu	Rina tied to rebirth — unpaid debts → soul returns until obligations fulfilled; linked to <i>samsara</i>
Buddhism	Rebirth without permanent soul (<i>anatman</i>) — karmic continuity, not fixed self; negligence of Dhamma → more births
Jainism	Rebirth linked to karma through passions & violence; <i>ahimsa</i> = way to cut the cycle
Advaita Vedanta	Samsara = ignorance-driven illusion (<i>maya</i>)
N.A. Nikam	Rebirth = not just punishment but opportunity — another chance to discharge debts & progress toward liberation
Vivekananda	Reframed rebirth as symbolic of moral accountability , not literal cycles
Ambedkar	Rejected rebirth framework — reinforces caste oppression; "debts of birth" justified social hierarchy
Ian Stevenson	Studies on past-life memories (contested) kept rebirth discussion alive in academic psychology
Contemporary	Symbolically: unfulfilled obligations return as crises for next generation. Climate change = "rebirth" of neglected debts

5. KARMA — Action, Work, Deed

KARMA = "Every action has consequences"

NOT Fatalism

It is ethical responsibility & empowerment

Tied to Rebirth

Current state = actions of past & present life

Nishkama Karma

Selfless action without fruits (Gita)

Interpretations of Karma

Scholar	Interpretation
N.A. Nikam	<i>Artha-kriya-karitra</i> — good actions produce good effects instantaneously and bad actions produce bad effects instantaneously
S. Radhakrishnan	"There is no doctrine so valuable in life and conduct as the karma theory — it implies hope for the future and resignation of the past"
Wilhelm Halbfass	Good intent + good deeds → good karma + happier rebirths; bad intent + bad deeds → bad karma + bad rebirths
Natural Science view	Man is product of evolution; karma asks man to "take conscious charge of his adventure"

Is Karma Fatalistic? — The Great Debate

KARMA AS FATALISM (Critics)

- **Max Weber (1958)**: Karma & rebirth = "closed social system" — people accepted their place, discouraging social change
- **Louis Dumont (1970)**: Karma = ideological basis of caste hierarchy; birth status justified by previous karma

KARMA AS ETHICAL RESPONSIBILITY (Counter)

- **Radhakrishnan (1937)**: Not deterministic; present choices shape future
- **Vivekananda**: "Man is maker of his destiny; each action plants a seed"
- **P.V. Kane**: Tied to Dharma — gives agency to act rightly in present

Key Distinction: *Fatalism* = everything is fixed → resignation | *Karma* = actions have consequences → individuals are **responsible** for shaping their lives

Nishkama Karma — The Gita's Ideal

Krishna to Arjuna (Bhagavad Gita, Ch. 2, Verse 47):

"To action alone hast thou a right, never at all to its fruits; let not the fruits of action be thy motive, nor let there be in thee any attachment to inaction."

- **Nishkama Karma Yoga** = yoga of **selfless action**
- Actions performed **without expectation of fruits**
- Purifies the mind → prepares for higher wisdom
- Way to liberation = not escape from action, but **action without attachment**

Karma, Rebirth & the Four Purusharthas

Purushartha	Karma Impact
Dharma	Righteous conduct → karma becomes <i>punya</i> → higher rebirth or liberation. E.g., earning wealth honestly, speaking truth
Artha	If gained through adharma → negative karma + bondage; if gained ethically & used for service → positive karma
Kama	Within Dharma (marriage, family) → good karma; without Dharma (lust, exploitation) → negative karma + lower rebirths
Moksha	Ultimate goal: transcend karma & rebirth cycle. Living with Dharma + moderating Artha & Kama → soul breaks free

Radhakrishnan:

"Karma is self-determined destiny, not blind fate."

6. CASTE AND THE CASTE SYSTEM (Paper 2, Ch. 3.2)

CASTE SYSTEM IN INDIA

DEFINITION

Kroeber (1930), Ghurye (1932)

VARNA vs JATI

4-fold vs local sub-classification

GHURYE'S 6 FEATURES

Birth, endogamy, hierarchy...

DUMONT

Purity/Pollution hierarchy

BUDDHISM & JAINISM

Reform movements

Definitions & Etymology

Kroeber (1930):

"Caste is an endogamous and hereditary subdivision of an ethnic unit occupying a position of superior or inferior rank or social esteem."

G.S. Ghurye (1932):

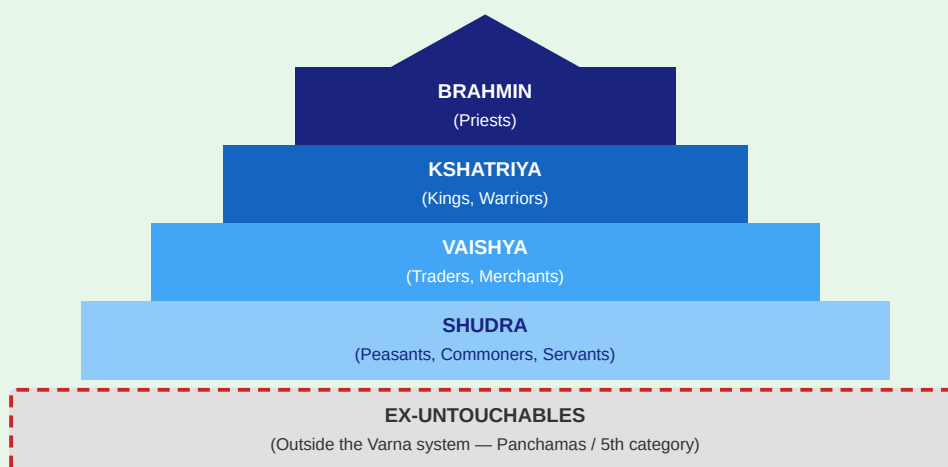
"Any attempt at definition is bound to fail because of the complexity of the phenomenon."

- 'Caste' from Portuguese "**casta**" = pure breed
- In Indian languages: two terms — **Varna** (colour; 4-fold division) and **Jati** (birth-based group)
- Those excluded from 4 Varnas = **Panchamas / fifth category** (outcastes, foreigners, slaves)

Varna vs Jati (Caste)

Category	Jati (Caste)	Varna
Meaning	Social group based on birth	Class system based on occupation
Origin	Developed over time through social stratification	Described in ancient Hindu texts as 4-fold division
Number	Thousands — vary by region & religion	Four: Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra
Mobility	Little to no social mobility	Theoretically can move based on occupation & behavior
Scope	Regional/local sub-classification	Broad all-India aggregative classification
Discrimination	Common feature of caste-based systems	Theoretically not discriminatory but used to justify it
Relevance	Still significant despite being officially outlawed	Largely superseded by caste in practice

VARNA HIERARCHY (Handwritten pyramid from class notes)



Higher = more ritually "pure" (Dumont) | Lower = closer to "polluting" occupations

Varna & Buddhism / Jainism — Reform Movements

Aspect	Buddhism	Jainism
Origin	6th c. BCE, Second Urbanisation — rejected Varna hierarchy	Same period — rejected Brahmanical ritualism & Varna
Key Teaching	Karma & intention (<i>cetana</i>) = basis of moral worth, not birth. <i>Vasala Sutta</i> : "By action one becomes a Brahmin or an outcaste"	Fundamental equality of all living beings (<i>jiva</i>); ahimsa = path to liberation for all regardless of caste
Key Scholars	Romila Thapar : product of & reaction to Varna stratification. Gail Omvedt : opened new moral order. Bronkhorst (2011) : weakened ritual economy placing Brahmins at top	Paul Dundas : liberation for all regardless of caste/gender. Padmanabh Jaini : ethics → personal discipline, not collective ritual. Hermann Jacobi : challenged Brahmanical orthodoxy
Appeal	Inclusive; used Pali (local language); attracted marginalized castes; Ambedkar : "religion of social equality"	Attractive in mercantile communities — spiritual justification for restraint & honest trade
Ethical Principles	Four Noble Truths; Eightfold Path; democratized access to Nirvana	Five vows (<i>mahavratas</i>): ahimsa, satya, asteya, brahmacharya, aparigraha; anekantavada (many-sidedness of truth)
Influence	Archaeological evidence: Sanchi & Bharhut inscriptions show patronage by guilds & non-elite groups	Shaped vegetarianism, Gandhian non-violence (<i>satyagraha</i>); fostered intellectual pluralism
Paradox	—	While theology egalitarian, Jain communities sometimes adopted caste-like structures (<i>jati</i>) in practice

G.S. Ghurye's Six Defining Features of Caste (1932)

#	Feature	Description
1	Segmentation by birth	Membership determined by birth ; hereditary system; one inherits caste identity
2	Endogamy	Restrictions on marrying outside caste; hypergamy allowed in some situations; sub-caste endogamy = principal feature
3	Hierarchical system	Generally Brahmins at head; disputed in some cases; hundreds of castes with gradation acknowledged by everyone
4	Restrictions on feeding & social intercourse	Minute rules on food/drink upper castes could accept from lower; lower castes generally accepted food from upper
5	Hereditary occupation	Lack of unrestricted choice of profession; caste members restricted from "degrading" professions. Note : missing from large parts of India per Ghurye
6	Segregation	Dominant caste in center, others on periphery; restrictions on water wells, streets by one caste on another

Limitations: Relied on colonial census reports & **H.H. Risley's** racist theories (1901 Census Commissioner). **Graham Chapman**: difference between theoretical constructs of caste & practical reality.

Louis Dumont — Caste & Hierarchy

Concept	Explanation
Purity-Pollution	Ritual rankings in Jati based on religious purity & pollution ; closer to sacred = pure = high status; distant = polluting = low status
Holism & Hierarchy	Caste = combination of difference/separation + holism/hierarchy ; each caste exists only in relation to totality of society
Complementarity	Castes are unequal but also complementary & non-competing groups ; each has own place, cannot be taken by another
Division of Labour	Since caste linked with occupation → functions as social division of labour ; in principle, allows no mobility
Power & Status	Material power (economic/military) closely associated with social status; defeated in wars → often assigned low caste status

How Caste Worked in Practice

- Upper/lower castes lived in **segregated colonies**; water wells not shared; Brahmins wouldn't accept food from Shudras
- Could only **marry within one's caste**
- System bestowed privileges on upper castes while sanctioning **repression** of lower castes
- Criticised for being **unjust & regressive** — trapping people into fixed social orders
- Despite obstacles: **BR Ambedkar** (authored Indian Constitution) and **KR Narayanan** (first Dalit president) rose to prominence
- Historians note: until 18th Century, formal distinctions were of limited importance — social identities were more **flexible**

Age of the Caste System

Period	Nature
Vedic Period (900–500 BCE)	Society organized into 4 varnas; divisions were relatively flexible with scope for mobility
Post-Vedic Period	Varna → rigid caste structure ; occupations & social status became fixed & hereditary
Overall age	Generally agreed: around 3,000 years ; nature has evolved over time

QUICK-REVISION CHEAT SHEET

Topic	Main Points (Keywords)	Key Scholars	Key Examples	Key Case Studies
Racial Classification	Anthropometry; Cephalic index; dolichocephalic; brachycephalisation; coefficient of racial likelihood; population genetics	Risley (1915), B.S. Guha (1931), S.S. Sarkar (1954), Haddon	1931 Census; Rajputs, Pathans, Marathas; Kadars (no Negrito)	Sarkar correcting Guha on Negrito element
Purushartha	Fourfold path; Dharma = CENTRAL; Artha = righteous wealth; Kama = all desires; Moksha = liberation from samsara; Trimarga; Four Yogas	P.V. Kane, Radhakrishnan, N.A. Nikam, Halbfass, Kautilya, Max Weber	SDGs; ESG; Greta Thunberg; mindfulness; yoga; civil service ethics	Yudhishtira-dog story (dharma > heaven); Nachiketa (knowledge > wealth)
Dharma vs Religion	Dharma = duty, moral law, cosmic order, inner compass; Religion = faith, belief, rituals; Sanatana Dharma; Dhamma; Ahimsa; Das-dharma	Radhakrishnan, Halbfass, Max Weber (on Buddhism)	Buddhism → Eightfold Path; Jainism → 10 virtues; Hindu → Purusharthas	Yudhishtira refusing to abandon dog for heaven
Varnashrama	Varna = WHAT; Ashrama = WHEN; Grihastha = MOST CRUCIAL; 4 stages; social harmony + personal discipline + spiritual purpose	P.V. Kane, Radhakrishnan, Ambedkar (critique)	NEP 2020; work-life balance; retirement planning; minimalism; eco-conscious living	Nachiketa (Brahmacharya ideal); Dhritarashtra-Gandhari (Vanaprastha); Yudhishtira's renunciation (Sannyasa)
Rina (Debt)	4 debts: Deva, Rishi, Pitra, Atithi; born in debt; karmic bondage; gratitude & interdependence; time-bound vs timeless; Western vs Indic	Kane, Arvind Sharma, Ambedkar (critique), Feminists	COVID community kitchens (Atithi Rina); organ donation (Pitra Rina); climate debt	Bhagavad Gita condemning those who take without giving
Karma	Action/deed; NOT fatalism but empowerment; artha-kriya-karitra; Nishkama Karma = selfless action; tied to rebirth; punya vs papa	N.A. Nikam, Radhakrishnan, Halbfass, Max Weber (critic), Louis Dumont (critic), Vivekananda, P.V. Kane	Bhagavad Gita Ch.2 V.47; natural evolution; ESG; conscious choices	Krishna-Arjuna dialogue on action without attachment
Rebirth	Soul persists after death; linked to karma; Satapatha Brahmana (origin); Samkhya tradition; nirvikalpa samadhi; anatman (Buddhist)	N.A. Nikam, Vivekananda, Ambedkar (rejected), Ian Stevenson, Radhakrishnan	Climate change as "rebirth of neglected debts"; New Age movements	Advaita Vedanta (maya/illusion) vs Nyaya-Vaisheshika (concrete karma process)
Caste System	Varna (4-fold, all-India) vs Jati (thousands, regional); Portuguese "casta"; Panchamas; endogamy; hierarchy; purity-pollution; birth-based; social division of labour	Kroeber (1930), Ghurye (1932), Louis Dumont (1970), H.H. Risley, Graham Chapman	BR Ambedkar (Constitution); KR Narayanan (first Dalit president); segregated colonies; water wells	Vedic flexibility → Post-Vedic rigidity; 3000-year-old institution
Buddhism & Caste	Rejected Varna hierarchy; karma & intention (cetana) > birth; Dhamma; Sangha; Pali language; Second Urbanisation; egalitarian	Romila Thapar, Gail Omvedt, Bronkhorst (2011), Ambedkar	Vasala Sutta; Sanchi & Bharhut inscriptions; guilds patronage	Ambedkar's "The Buddha and His Dhamma" — Buddhism as social equality
Jainism & Caste	Sramana tradition; ahimsa; equality of all jiva; 5 mahavratas; anekantavada (many-sidedness); personal discipline; honest trade	Paul Dundas, Padmanabh Jaini, Hermann Jacobi	Gandhi's satyagraha (Jain influence); vegetarianism; mercantile communities	Paradox: egalitarian theology but caste-like structures in practice

BUILDING BLOCKS — Most Important Scholars & Examples per Topic

Block 1: PURUSHARTHA & DHARMA

Top Scholars: P.V. Kane (4 dimensions of Dharma), Radhakrishnan ("principle of right living"), Wilhelm Halbfass (dharma ≠ religion), N.A. Nikam (moksha = river joining ocean)

Must-Use Examples: Yudhishtira-dog story (dharma > heaven), Bhagavad Gita Nishkama Karma (Ch.2, V.47), SDGs as modern Purushartha, ESG = Artha under Dharma, Kautilya's Arthashastra

Best for Questions on: Traditional Indian social system, ethics in governance, Indian philosophy vs Western

Block 2: VARNASHRAMA DHARMA

Top Scholars: P.V. Kane (Varna-duty = repaying debts), Radhakrishnan (framework prevents one-sided development), Ambedkar (critique: duties tied to birth, not choice)

Must-Use Examples: Nachiketa (ideal Brahmachari), Dhritarashtra-Gandhari (Vanaprastha), Yudhishtira's renunciation (Sannyasa), NEP 2020 (modern Brahmacharya), Minimalism (modern Sannyasa)

Best for Questions on: Structure of traditional Indian society, continuity & change, caste & social organization

Block 3: RINA & REBIRTH

Top Scholars: Arvind Sharma (duties > rights in Hindu ethics), N.A. Nikam (rebirth = opportunity), Ambedkar (rejected rebirth as justifying caste), Feminist scholars (women's unpaid labor = unrecognized Rina)

Must-Use Examples: COVID community kitchens (Atithi Rina), organ donation (Pitra Rina), climate debt as Deva Rina, zakat/tithe vs Rinna (Western vs Indic), SC framing rights within fundamental duties

Best for Questions on: Indian social system, duty vs rights, obligation frameworks, contemporary relevance of tradition

Block 4: KARMA

Top Scholars: Radhakrishnan ("self-determined destiny, not blind fate"), Vivekananda ("man is maker of his destiny"), Max Weber (critic: "closed social system"), Louis Dumont (karma = ideological basis of caste), N.A. Nikam (artha-kriya-karitra)

Must-Use Examples: Bhagavad Gita Ch.2 V.47 (action without attachment), Fatalism vs Empowerment distinction, Nishkama Karma as ideal for civil servants

Best for Questions on: Philosophical basis of Indian society, fatalism debate, ethics, caste ideology

Block 5: CASTE SYSTEM — STRUCTURE & FEATURES

Top Scholars: Kroeber (definition), G.S. Ghurye (6 features, 1932), Louis Dumont (purity-pollution, Homo Hierarchicus 1970), Graham Chapman (theoretical vs practical reality), H.H. Risley (1901 Census — criticized)

Must-Use Examples: Portuguese "casta", Varna (4) vs Jati (thousands), Panchamas (fifth category), segregated colonies, water wells, BR Ambedkar + KR Narayanan rising above caste, 18th century flexibility

Best for Questions on: Caste system structure, hierarchy, features, how caste works, social stratification

Block 6: REFORM MOVEMENTS — BUDDHISM & JAINISM vs VARNA

Top Scholars: Romila Thapar (Buddhism = reaction to Varna), Gail Omvedt (new moral order based on conduct), Bronkhorst (weakened ritual economy), Ambedkar ("religion of social equality"), Paul Dundas (liberation for all), Padmanabh Jaini (ethics → personal discipline), Hermann Jacobi (challenged Brahmanical orthodoxy)

Must-Use Examples: Vasala Sutta (not by birth, by action), Sanchi-Bharhut inscriptions, anekantavada (intellectual pluralism), Gandhi's satyagraha (Jain roots), Buddhist Sangha using Pali, mercantile community adoption of Jainism

Best for Questions on: Social reform, egalitarianism, impact of religion on society, change & continuity, caste critique

Block 7: RACIAL CLASSIFICATION

Top Scholars: Risley (7 types, 1915 — first attempt), B.S. Guha (1931 Census, 6 divisions), S.S. Sarkar (cephalic index, 1954 — corrected Guha), Haddon (oldest = pre-Dravidian tribes)

Must-Use Examples: Coefficient of racial likelihood (Guha's method), dolichocephalic (long-headed — India's main type per Sarkar), Irano-Scythian & Far Eastern (Sarkar's additions), shift from racial typology → population genetics

Best for Questions on: Ethnic & linguistic elements, Indian population classification, physical anthropology methods